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THE DOCTRINE OF CREATION AND THE TASK OF THEOLOGY

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“One is never done with Schleiermacher,”¹ Karl Barth once wrote, and those who have read *Church Dogmatics* know just how true that is. Schleiermacher’s work presents a constant task for theology to incorporate fully and critique its sophisticated method; to follow its rigorous passion for ethics; to imitate, if only palely, its synthetic power and breadth; to stand open-eyed before its beauty and elegant simplicity. Barth knew this well. To read his *Church Dogmatics* carefully is to hear Barth’s respect for Schleiermacher on every page. The dispute with Schleiermacher’s method and doctrine, far from being dismissed, courses through the *Dogmatics*, paying tribute to the gift and the burden of Schleiermacher’s thought to his descendants.

The exact nature of Barth’s dispute with Schleiermacher and the path that led not away from but *through* him has now been examined and rehearsed carefully in scholarly circles.² Schleiermacher’s place in German letters and philosophy, his indebtedness to idealisms of several sorts, and his part in the new definitions of family and state all have received fresh interpretation outside the well-worn labels Barth applied to theology since Schleiermacher.³ The richness and complexity of this scholarly debate,

¹Barth often spoke of his unfinished relationship to Schleiermacher. See, for example, Karl Barth, *The Theology of Schleiermacher: Lectures at Göttingen* (ed. Dietrich Ritschl; trans. G. W. Bromiley; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1982) 277.

²See, for example, James O. Duke and Robert F. Streetman, *Barth and Schleiermacher: Beyond the Impasse?* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1988); George Lindbeck, *The Nature of Doctrine* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1984); and Brian Gerrish, *Tradition and the Modern World* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1978).

³Schleiermacher scholarship is an industry. Terrance Tice has published a bibliography for the English-speaking world and has recently amplified it in a new edition. See Terrance Tice, *A Schleiermacher Bibliography* (2d ed.; Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985). I have worked from two older studies: Richard B. Brandt’s *Schleiermacher’s Philosophy* (New York: Harper & Row, 1941) and Richard R. Niebuhr’s *Schleiermacher on Christ and Religion*

however, have not yet found their way into much constructive, doctrinal theology.

Contemporary theologians by and large believe they are done with Schleiermacher. On one hand, they have assumed that trumpet calls of "objectivity" and "no to natural theology" have put an enemy to rout. On the other, they assume that Schleiermacher can be remembered only for his method, which they read in his Introduction to the *Christian Faith*, and abandoned long ago. In this second assumption, I believe, these theologians are mistaken. The method, at least, of much contemporary theology remains indebted to liberalism, or more precisely, to Schleiermacher. What Hans Frei called "relational theology" remains a remarkably refined, flexible, and widely used instrument today.⁴ Contemporary method in theology would benefit from a direct study and acknowledgment of the author of all theologies of experience. Moreover, those theologians committed to a revisioning of the doctrine of creation will find both their method and their doctrine challenged and instructed by this doctor of the church.

As Brian Gerrish has written, theology students have been taught to know Schleiermacher as a genius of method, not doctrine. They have been handed, with dutiful care, the second of Schleiermacher's *Speeches to Cultured*

(New York: Scribner's, 1964). More recent works supporting and at times correcting these ground-breaking studies, are Terrance Tice's "Schleiermacher's Theological Method" (Th.D. diss., Princeton Theological Seminary, 1961); John Thiel's *God and World in Schleiermacher's "Dialektik and Glaubenslehre"* (Bern: Lang, 1981); William Johnson's *Schleiermacher and Nygren* (Leiden: Brill, 1964); Martin Redeker's *Schleiermacher's Life and Thought* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1973); Kathryn Tanner's *God and Creation in Modern Theology* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1988). A few surveys I have found particularly helpful are Emanuel Hirsch's *Geschichte der Neuern Evangelischen Theologie* (5 vols.; Gütersloh: Bertelsmann, 1949) vols. 4 and 5; Hugh R. Mackintosh's *Types of Modern Theology* (New York: Scribner's, 1937); and George Rupp's *Culture Protestantism* (Missoula, MT: Scholars Press, 1977).

I have used two editions of Schleiermacher's work: *Der Christliche Glaube* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 1960) and *The Christian Faith* (trans. Hugh R. Mackintosh and James S. Stewart; Philadelphia: Fortress, 1976).

Karl Barth, though an interested party, was a remarkably keen and subtle interpreter of Schleiermacher. His lectures on Schleiermacher (*The Theology of Schleiermacher*) and his addresses ("Schicksal und Idee in der Theologie" in *Gesammelte Vorträge*, vol. 3: *Theologische Fragen und Antworten* [Zürich: Evangelischer Verlag, 1957] and "Dogmenprinzip bei Wilhelm Herrmann" in *Gesammelte Vorträge*, vol. 2: *Die Theologie und die Kirche* [Zürich: Evangelischer Verlag, n.d.]) show his mastery and innovation in the interpretation of nineteenth-century religious thought.

⁴The term stems from Hans Frei's dissertation ("The Doctrine of Revelation in the Thought of Karl Barth, 1909 to 1922: The Nature of Barth's Break with Liberalism" [Ph.D. diss., Yale University, 1956]), a masterful interpretation of Barth and Schleiermacher-inspired liberalism.

Despisers and several propositions borrowed from the Introduction to the *Christian Faith* and have emerged from their study laden with his technical terms but certainly not delighted with the doctrine that rises gracefully from its foundation.⁵ For Schleiermacher to take his place again in theology, his constructive work must be allowed to speak. Perhaps it is true that we can never have enough method, but it is in doctrine that Schleiermacher's method reveals its power and finds its appointed end. Schleiermacher's method is misunderstood if studied apart from his doctrine. Indeed, as I argue here, Schleiermacher's true intent in method—what I call a method of “indirectness”—is revealed not in the celebrated Introduction to the *Christian Faith* but in its doctrine. In the First Part of the “System of Doctrine,” the doctrine of creation and preservation, Schleiermacher displays the full richness of his system and justifies Barth's claim—and threat—that we are never done with him.

Schleiermacher's doctrine of creation consists of more than a particularly sophisticated treatment of the divine intention for the created; it represents his method, instantiated and placed in the service of theology. The tradition that rises from Schleiermacher and runs in its own way through Ritschl, Hermann, Troeltsch, and Barth, is stamped by Christology. It is conformed or centered in Christ and takes up its life from the constraints and grace of this doctrine. I underscore this interpretation because I do not wish to stir the fire that Brunner and Barth ignited and that is at long last dying away in embers. In my view, Schleiermacher is neither a “mystic” nor, subtly, a “natural theologian.” Schleiermacher does move, however, from a kind of pure category of creation to its realization in Christology, or, more polemically, he abstracts from his central reality, Christ, to the form of relation between God and creation that underlies all piety. God and the world are given together in experience, Schleiermacher insists, and that relation is both doctrine and method. They are given together perfectly—though not uniquely—in Christ; that will be Schleiermacher's Christology. They are given immediately to Christian piety; that is his doctrine of creation and his method of deriving it. Schleiermacher's method stands before us in full view, then, in this First Part of the *Christian Faith*, “unencumbered” from the historical particulars of Christology. The full weight and power of Schleiermacher's method, its gifts and burdens to theology, are in the balance here.

Despite his well-known reservations about the order of the First and Second Part of the System, and his not-so-secret preference for the “first form” of dogmatic utterance that gives voice only to pious experience, Schleiermacher resolutely began his discussion with the classic and persist-

⁵Brian Gerrish, *A Prince of the Church* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1984) 17–18.

ing dilemmas of the Christian account of creation. The problems of creation *ex nihilo*, the necessity and eternity of creation, the relation of the ideal to the real in the created realm—all these Schleiermacher addresses and resolves in a strikingly brief compass. From there, he moves in full stride to the doctrine of preservation, the true center of the First Part. The attributes of God, the perfection of the world and the human person, the troubling questions raised about causality and, more importantly, about pantheism are set out and combined in a system of quiet elegance and power.

To read Schleiermacher attentively is an aesthetic experience. I underscore the beauty of Schleiermacher's doctrine in part because it is sometimes overshadowed by such a ponderous, desiccated style and because it offers a royal road into Schleiermacher's system as a whole. The whole of his thought is caught up in the part, and the part in turn encompasses and raises up the whole. This graceful movement between whole and part, a dissolving and reemergence of each in the other, characterizes Schleiermacher's thought from the time of the *Speeches* forward. It calls to mind his early tribute to piety as well as his later ordering of the realm of religion within the world of thought and action. It characterizes his Christology, in which the whole church is caught up in the blessedness realized in the one redeemer. Such complex separation and union between thought and being lies at the heart of both idealism and relational theology. The love of this dialectic, although hard to acquire, is never easily lost. To see the whole in the part, the eternal in the finite, the perfect in the real, and all these in the other, is to be grasped by the aesthetic power and systematic elegance of Schleiermacher's doctrine. This experience draws our attention to the principle of dialectic that underlies Schleiermacher's system; it kindles our appreciation and our knowledge of the *Christian Faith*. But it also hinders exposition.

Unlike Schleiermacher, the commentator scarcely knows where to begin. Christian doctrine, however complex in method, tends to harden and become reduced to propositions once repeated. Even absolute idealism, a fully dialectical theology of right-wing Hegelianism, threatens to collapse into rationalism when set out as doctrine. This danger lies very close at hand with Schleiermacher. Too often the *Christian Faith* is presented as a static and ordered whole, treating God, the self, and the world as discrete elements, each waiting their turn for doctrinal attention. It is as though these elements of the system were objects, stubborn facts that offered a choice to the theologian: Does God create the universe or the form? Does God preserve the individual or the whole? Does God cause everything or merely the good? Or perhaps more pressing: In our piety, do we commune with God or the world? Do we depend utterly on God alone or on our common

life? Do we receive blessing through the Savior or the church? Such questions dog our steps and increase the more we pursue this propositional interpretation. Indeed, Schleiermacher himself prepares this detour from his main path. The *Christian Faith* bristles with choices between propositions of just the kind I raised before. In the doctrine of creation and preservation alone, he proposes dogmatic statements about divine causality, angels and devils, the relation of science and piety, free will and evil, and the divine attributes that are presupposed in all other doctrines. These can be summarized, and often are; they represent Schleiermacher's system of doctrine, passed on to his disciples. While valuable, these propositions in the end mislead. Like many distillations, they exchange liveliness for purity.

It may be that misgivings of just this kind have driven many English-speaking scholars away from Schleiermacher's doctrine to his method, laid out in the Introduction. Perhaps they sense the life of Schleiermacher's system there, unconstrained and ranging freely over the "borrowings" from German high culture. The dilemma facing those who press on to doctrine is twofold: to preserve the method—the life—in the content and to bind up the whole in the part, exhibiting Schleiermacher's vision of the inexpressible, breathtaking unity of God and the world, given together in experience.

Any starting point fails in its own way; we must simply step into the stream. I begin, then, with Schleiermacher's definition of the part, the individual set over against the whole. This may seem an odd place to begin, since Schleiermacher has earned a reputation as a theologian of the whole. He spent the early part of his career influenced by and influencing German romanticism and exhibited that romantic "taste for the infinite" well into his maturity. In those years, his thought first became entangled with Spinoza's, a relationship he could never quite shake off. What is more, Schleiermacher was a distinguished Platonist. He translated the Dialogues into German and preserved that longing for the One and the All that illumines the life of contemplation. Throughout the *Christian Faith* Schleiermacher sounds these themes: his is a world of "organic wholes," of forces knit together, of reciprocity, and of *Naturzusammenhang*, the integrated whole of nature. Such a list prompts Brian Gerrish to declare that Schleiermacher considered God's providence to extend not to the individual but to the whole:

Schleiermacher will not allow us to think of God as producing, like the human self, individual acts of will. His entire case for the coextensiveness of divine and natural causation seems, in fact, to have a very important implication for the idea of providence, one that puts him at loggerheads with Calvin: the unit of divine care, so to say, is the whole rather than its parts. If we may put the question a little

crudely: Does it not follow that God ordains everything in general and nothing in particular? In a sense, I think the answer has to be yes. . . . The particular event, for Schleiermacher, is included in the activity of providence in the sense that it is a part of the whole system of nature.⁶

Inexorably, Schleiermacher seems led to deny the part for the whole. The gauge of his technical instruments appears set for large measures: for the system of nature, for the universe, for the community, for the *telos* of history—all unified in their utter dependence upon God. Examples of this “hunger for wholeness” nearly overwhelm the First Part of Doctrine. I acknowledge all this, but nevertheless believe that Schleiermacher’s doctrine of creation preserves, honors, and, rightly begins with the individual.

This is no small matter for Christian thought. It is not simply that the older Protestant tradition has placed the individual within God’s particular providence, as an object of special care, nor that modern, liberal thought has stubbornly clung to the irreducible fact of individual life. The place of the individual within systems of thought and praxis remains an open question. It is too tempting to imagine that the problem of the individual springs only from a bourgeois heart. To be sure, the individual possesses infinite worth for sturdy liberals like Harnack and Ritschl, and even Hermann Cohen, but so thoroughgoing a Marxist as Cornel West also finds religion committed to the life, singularity, and worth of the individual.⁷

Nevertheless, Christian thought makes an uneasy alliance with individualism. Christian theology hears no call to establish a theory of the good that rests on the cold neutrality of agents, reified and equal before the law. Its pronounced sympathy to socialism—even if of the utopian sort—and its intimacy with affliction and need draw Christianity near to those who stand together, not apart, and to the good that binds up the lost into the whole. For this reason, Christian theology has scant interest in “thin theories of the good,” and remains vulnerable to swift attack when it aligns itself to theories of culture, especially high culture. Such “Culture-Protestantism,” of course, exists, and Christian theology has long had a share in the thought forms and practice of the elite. I could scarcely advocate the study of Schleiermacher if I considered theology little more than unavowed culture criticism or revolutionary theory. Still, Christian theology yields not an essence but a kind of “living tradition” or an “idea,” as John Henry Newman

⁶Brian Gerrish, *Tradition and the Modern World*, 108–9.

⁷I hasten to add, a most sophisticated neo-Marxist, influenced by American pragmatists and post-structuralist thought. See Cornel West, *Prophesy Deliverance!* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1982) 15–24, 95–127.

put it, that calls Christianity to the poor, the suffering, and to those great classes of the earth who are forced to eat their bread in sorrow.⁸

On such grounds it is possible to conclude that Christianity turns to the individual only in disobedience, pitilessly ignoring the structures of oppression and blind to the unified good that underlies justice and orders the system of nature. Christian theology is rightly drawn to the one, the group, the good of the whole. It is marked by deep strains of passion for the “thick theory of the good,” for the life together in which the self is but part of the body, lifeless apart from it. These are affiliations or sympathies the Christian theologian ignores at some risk. I wish nevertheless to point to another strain, another tendency in Christian thought: the dignity and singularity of the individual.

The biblical and historical sources of Christian theology are replete with the details and contradictions of individual life. The Scriptures record among the people Israel and the early church the lives of distinct personalities, of particular men and women whose inner world is not exhausted in their deeds and whose work as exemplars does not fully define or reduce them. Not merely the figures we know best—David and Saul; Rebekah and Isaac; Naomi, Ruth, and Daniel; Mary and Peter—not merely these, but those on either side of the great ones—Miriam and Aaron; Tamar and Absalom; the Magdalen and Stephen Martyr. All these individuals stand before us, sturdy and vivid, a living presence from the past. The Scriptures open up a world in which God meets, addresses, and knows the individual not simply as part of the whole, but as uniquely made by and for God. The particularity of the individual belongs to Christian theology because its presence marks the place where all idealisms are broken open for divine revelation.⁹ The importance of the individual, then, cannot be lost on theology, and in the effort to judge Schleiermacher’s thought, this question remains: Can we see the *Christian Faith* as a work not only of the whole, but of the part as well?

I believe that to do so is possible and, moreover, faithful to Schleiermacher’s intent in the doctrine of creation. It helps to reconcile his romantic interest

⁸John Henry Newman, *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine* (Garden City, NY: Image Books/Doubleday, 1960) esp. chap. 1.

⁹I take this to be the methodological claim advanced by Barth throughout his work, but especially prominent in his early essays in *Word of God and the Word of Man* (trans. Douglas Horton; New York: Harper & Row, 1957) and “Schicksal und Idee in der Theologie”; and by Franz Rosenzweig in *The Star of Redemption* (trans. W. Hallo; Notre Dame: Notre Dame University Press, 1985). To be sure, such critique of idealism is not a modern concern exclusively. Both Barth and Rosenzweig, as well as secular theorists, leaned upon Kierkegaard, whose writings were just appearing in German journals during those years.

in unique character and his philosophical attraction to monism. Schleiermacher's proposals in the doctrine of creation and providence, furthermore, offer an advantage to modern theology that Barth's, for example, do not. Schleiermacher's doctrine points not away from but toward the human resolution of contradiction. Barth, in the *Dogmatics*, was fond of reconciling the contradictions in the doctrine of providence—between particular and general—and in the doctrine of creation—between the individual and the whole—through a characteristic pointing away from human solutions to divine ones. In part, Barth could be said simply to follow Schleiermacher here. From Schleiermacher, Barth could have learned the methodological insistence that God is above or free from any created contradiction. The God intimated in the *Christian Faith* rises in sovereign isolation and power over every dialectic of worldly existence. But Schleiermacher pursues this dialectic between individual and whole within the created world in a way that Barth would not and could not. He offers not a means to balance the two, or on the other hand to conflate them, but a thought world that draws them into his characteristic unity within difference.

In a few bold strokes, Schleiermacher sketches his position. At its heart, this solution draws its life from the dialectic, the concept Hans Frei has called "relation."¹⁰ In discussing divine omniscience, Schleiermacher baldly asserts that "this question [whether even the trivial is an object of the divine knowledge] could simply not have been raised if a start had been made from the formula that God knows each in the whole, as also the whole in each."¹¹ He leaves behind a hint about the significance of this "formula": "This follows of itself for in fact we consider even a human consciousness more perfect [*vollkommener*] the more there is present to it in each individual moment."¹² But just what can it mean to know "each in the whole. . . the whole in each"?

Here we come at last to Schleiermacher's most characteristic and well-known conception of the world as a created order, the *Naturzusammenhang*, the integrated world of nature. At times, this elusive term is translated as "causal nexus," and certainly Schleiermacher gives ample ground for such translation, but we must be cautious in its use. Despite his emphatic support for "material causality" in his discussion—and dismissal—of miracles,¹³

¹⁰Frei, "The Doctrine of Revelation in the Thought of Karl Barth," esp. chap. 2.

¹¹Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 227; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 300. Schleiermacher pursues a similar train of thought in his hermeneutics; see his "The Academy Addresses" in idem, *Hermeneutics: the Handwritten Manuscripts* (ed. Heinz Kimmerle; trans. James Duke and Jack Forstman; Missoula: Scholars Press, 1977), particularly the second address.

¹²Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 227; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 300.

¹³Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 178–84; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 234–42.

Schleiermacher does not offer us a Kantian world view, in which the realm of appearance is governed by iron causality and only the noumenal can speak of freedom. Rather, Schleiermacher includes freedom within the ordered world, and both are absolutely dependent on their Creator. We are to see our world as a thick and living community of "relations"; each individual related to the other, these to the whole, and all tied together in partial freedom and partial dependence. This is so frequently described as a "web" or "fabric" that these metaphors have given over their life to a static cliché, but they are suggestive of Schleiermacher's intent all the same. The force that "holds nature together," if we give his term its literal meaning, is not so much causality as it is relation; his is a world not of determinism but of connection and association. Or to express this a bit more exactly: causality is but one form of the unifying category, relation.

In the end, this is an intuitive or aesthetic description, and a closer analysis exchanges clarity for a living reality. At best we can only sketch examples. We can begin with a modern term for which Schleiermacher might have found sympathy: the ecosystem. Here we are offered a picture of interconnection, each species dependent on the next for its life, each required as food or shelter for another. An ecosystem out of balance cannot sustain life, even if the prized species are protected, because the complex environment in which the individual comes to life has deteriorated; in the end, nothing lives without the whole. Drawn with more detail, this picture exhibits the life of the whole within the part. The individual, or the single species, can be defined as the sum of its ecological niche. Each bird encompasses its food chain, its habitat, its predators; the whole is implied in its part. In turn, the environmental whole takes its life from each organic and inorganic thing within it. Even closer to Schleiermacher's image, the ecosystem lives. It grows and changes; a collection of the conscious and inanimate, it breathes life and orders the living within chains of relation. In some such way, each life is the whole; the whole, each.

We have figured here, however, without the human actor, without the freedom and passivity of human consciousness. The ecosystem, however mobile and mutable, can remain a network of causes, a living yet closed determinism. Schleiermacher asks more of our models than this. *Natur-zusammenhang* both encloses and rises to self-consciousness in the human person. Developing his methodological premise that God and the world are given originally in consciousness, Schleiermacher carefully sets out the dialectic unity of self and nature:

But though in our self-consciousness we constantly distinguish the system of relations [*Organisation*] from the spirit [*Geist*] in ourselves,

nevertheless the system is seated in the spirit as its original possession [*ursprüngliche Habe*], original just because there is a system of nature. . . This system, however, is not posited as having limits; hence it contains within itself all finite being, only in undeveloped form. If we extend our self-consciousness to that of the human species, then the whole earth co-positd with its external relations is equally undeveloped, partly as that which is possessed by us and partly as that which stands over against us [*entgegengesetzt*]. But that which stands over against us is only in self-consciousness so far as it affects us, and consequently exists along with us in a nature-system [*Naturzusammenhang*]; and thus also the whole system of nature or the world exists in our self-consciousness in so far as we recognize ourselves to be a part of the world.¹⁴

Here Schleiermacher asks us to see the world, created by God, as a system of association brought into relation with human awareness. Human beings are marked by self-consciousness, Schleiermacher informs us in his celebrated Introduction. They do not simply experience themselves, or their world; they take up the world, the “other,” into themselves, recognize it and recognize themselves in this act of experience. For Schleiermacher, this delicate interplay between the subject and object is the essence of the dialectic. It is neither pure knowledge, especially not of the Absolute or by it, nor is it pure practice, even of the artisan taking in and taking over the object. The dialectic in Schleiermacher’s thought rests in that moment between the poles of doing and knowing, that measureless point where subject and object join and then fall apart into objects once again. In this passage, Schleiermacher seems to strain for the primary experience, “uttered in speech,”¹⁵ hoping to capture in formal terms an inexpressible moment of identity and difference.

The world, as a system of nature, lives within the human subject precisely because the subject recognizes itself within the world. It is the strength and deep attraction of relationalism that the definition of the real encompasses and gives itself over to the ideal. Schleiermacher at once expands the individual, to cover the human species and all that is “undeveloped,” and refines it, to bring all sense impression under the mechanism that defines individual life. To say that my identity as an individual is the self-conscious recognition of the world is to say much more than that I am a part of all I meet or that, upon death, I reenter the “web of life.” It is to say that examined from the aspect of the whole, I *am* my relations. Each

¹⁴Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 138; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 181.

¹⁵Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 76; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 105.

individual is incomprehensible without the others that give it life, that influence, nurture, and oppose it; inexplicable without the causal mechanisms that govern physical life; unintelligible without the historical, social, and political connections that define human existence. From the point of view of the whole, I am exhausted in my relationships.

But—and relational theology lives by this “but”—from the point of view of the part, the individual exceeds and comprehends the whole. In part this is because, in Schleiermacher’s system, the individual knows the world through its presence, its “original givenness,” in human self-consciousness. For me to exist, in Schleiermacher’s terms, is to contain the world within my own receptivity and action. To press this definition a bit further: the “copositing” of self and world within consciousness implies that in each individual we see the world. Each person sums up or completes the whole. When we gaze through Schleiermacher’s eyes, we catch in each human life the totality of historical and natural relations, all bearing down on one another, all working together and directed toward one end, namely, to bring about and to be represented in this particular and irreducible self. It is this side of Schleiermacher’s thought that pays tribute to the insistence of the romantics on the unique power and worth of individual character, the richness of each person’s gifts, and the inner necessity of their guidance and development. We do not lose the world, Schleiermacher seems to say, when we turn our attention to the self; we gain it through its expression in the self. For this reason, Schleiermacher can argue that God’s providence extends to the whole through the divine preservation of each individual. God’s creative agency—the divine “absolute causality”—directs itself to the system of nature. Not to the whole, nor to the individual alone, but to the “whole in each; to each in the whole”—to this rising up and dissolving of the individual and the world Schleiermacher directs God’s providential and creative grace. We may say that God wills either the individual, each single and particular thing however small, or that God wills the whole, the species, the planet, the cosmos. Understood properly, Schleiermacher teaches, they are the same.

Like any systematic thinker, Schleiermacher evolves his entire thought world from each starting point. In this delicate establishment and dissolution of the individual, Schleiermacher’s method of opposition and identity is laid bare. Furthermore his Christology, an elaboration of the whole creation caught up and perfected in the one individual, is foreshadowed and outlined in this doctrine of creation. It is not necessary, however, to reach forward and back to see the influence of this starting point on the system of the *Christian Faith*. Within the doctrine of creation itself, the relation between part and whole offers a high ground where the other elements of this doctrine can be viewed and brought together. All of the elements within

the First Part of Doctrine—the celebrated “two-step creation,” the identity of creation and preservation, and the distinction of the eternal omnipotence from the created realm—rise up effortlessly from a single, dynamic origin, namely, the original perfection of the world and the self.

An exposition of these themes must wait on a valuation of this origin. What can Christian theology, caught up in its compassion and wonder at creation, take up and leave behind in Schleiermacher's doctrine of self and whole? Protestant liberalism shows its real strength here because it can speak directly and at length about the world, and its voice can be heard, clearly and without translation, by most contemporary Christian thinkers. This is not an unmixed blessing, of course. Those who have been seared by neo-orthodoxy hear in liberalism's appeal to the world the warning Karl Barth issued against all “natural theology.” But we also must listen for Schleiermacher's voice, all the same: what is his instruction for the church today?

His first lesson is that the opposition between the individual and the collective is a false one, and that the question whether Christian thought addresses the particular or the whole is what we might call a non-starter. We must not begin here, nor accept these terms of debate. The individual and the whole are related dialectically, each representing, encompassing, and completing the other. Schleiermacher offers us here a profound analysis of created life that opens up an escape from that bitter and deeply tiresome litmus test of political progress and reaction. It is not enough—or perhaps I mean, it is too much—to say that the personal is the political: we shall never begin to understand the complexity and irreducible contradiction of human life if we insist that the category of the self can be reduced or exhausted in the whole. We must say more: the self that is fully explained in the terms of the whole—by class, by gender, by political structures—is a self “de-created,” living and gaining force against the will of the Creator. To write Christian theology as though God did not will, address, judge, prize, and call home the particular individual is to ignore the dialectic of the whole and the part. “Theology is written for *you*,” Barth used to say,¹⁶ and until we feel the crushing weight of this divine encounter, until we limp from this night of wrestling, we have not understood what it means to speak of God as Creator. In each person, the creation is caught up and expressed; in each self, the intention of the Creator is summed

¹⁶Like his teacher Herrmann, Barth often appealed directly to his readers. See, for example, his address to the reader on the doctrine of election, *Church Dogmatics* (ed. and trans. G. W. Bromiley and T. F. Torrance; 5 vols.; Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1957) 2. 323–25.

up, crystallized, and judged. This mystery, Schleiermacher teaches us, is what it means to speak of the "consciousness of God."¹⁷

We cannot allow this to stand, one-sided, directly, and undialectically expressed. I contain the world, yes; it is my inheritance and the foundation of my agency. But the world also contains me. Any woman who, imagining that home and family offer a retreat from the world, turns there and finds the political, and finds it especially there, knows that the world contains and defines the self. The analysis of the most private of human emotions and ties, the passion of our loves and fears, our abilities and failures, are, in reality, our most public and structural possessions. I cannot penetrate to the heart of what I call my identity until I understand class or ethnicity. I cannot speak of my place within the world until I recognize the irresistible and brutal force that breaks down my barriers, claims me, and conforms me to this world. The world of nature—at times a frontier of great beauty and majesty, at times a field of terrible decay and destruction—defines and encircles the self. It does not take Pascal, after all, to teach us that our minds are frailty itself. To experience ourselves as part of nature, an animal poorly suited yet created for nature, is to understand our relation to and dissolution in the whole. A Christian theology that cannot speak of this whole, this created order that is the object of God's gracious will, cannot lay claim to a doctrine of creation. Schleiermacher teaches us that neither human beings nor the human species alone are the center of creation, nor its sole perfection. The whole system of nature is the object of divine mercy and judgment, and we take up our life within it. The ecological impulse in contemporary theology finds a loyal ally in Schleiermacher and his vision of the system of nature.

At the same time, however, the axioms that undergird his doctrine of creation no longer bind us. The mechanism that operates this complex machinery of part and whole has broken down in our time. Human consciousness, as Schleiermacher described it, may be a delicate communion of subject and object; it may contain within it a "species consciousness"; and it may point inutterably to a point of absoluteness, joining and surrounding it. But a little introspection also suggests that it may not. It is not just materialism, or historical materialism, or physicalism, or a doctrine of sin that undercuts Schleiermacher's method for us; his system could accommodate all these. The crucial shock to the foundation, I believe, is delivered by a kind of relativism, or "uncertainty principle." The axioms of Schleiermacher's method fit together so wonderfully because they are cer-

¹⁷Schleiermacher's celebrated definition of God-consciousness is found in *Christian Faith*, 12; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 23.

tain, *given* to experience. Notions of development, self-consciousness, piety, and ethics were all assumed as the common property of nineteenth-century religious thought. I would not go so far as to argue that they have disappeared. In fact the vital presence of Schleiermacher's thought today is tribute to their power. But they are no longer immediately and originally given to thought. They are now the relative values and insights, the thought form of Schleiermacher's world, that we receive, weigh, and at times discard from the nineteenth century. Now we could say, certainly, that theology has no need of foundational method, and freely give Schleiermacher's method over to the constructed realm of coherentism. There is much to be said for this kind of salvage effort. We could also say that all modern attempts to comprehend the past are now coherentist in character. In affirming this, however, we have weakened further the axioms that were given in Schleiermacher's method and have made his dialectical method more remote as a starting point for theology.

What is required is a new axiom, a new thought world that may be neither purely foundational nor coherentist but that we may consider given, that carries the conviction of the real.¹⁸ I propose that Christian theology recast Schleiermacher's method in the form of a "method of indirectness." This renovation would remove the old hardware of Schleiermacher's method: his understanding of development, of dialectical self-consciousness, and of fellow feeling, and the "natural orders" of society. His dialectical method, however, remains, now fitted out with the principle of indirectness. Much work has been done in the investigation of "indirect communication": the conceptions of metaphor and narrative in theology; the use of parable and sign in New Testament studies; the language of analogy and mystery in scholastic thought. Any proposal in this area can only gratefully acknowledge the vast and complex field that stretches out before it. I certainly do not claim novelty for my proposal, and its use as a methodological principle belongs by right to Søren Kierkegaard and the young Karl Barth.¹⁹ I mean to suggest here only that "indirectness" is a remarkably rich theological category and can be seen as the unifying tendency of Christian thought in our culture. We might apply it across the spectrum: to Christian interpretation of its past; to proclamation of Scripture; to theological statements

¹⁸The reader will notice that I have attempted to skate briskly over very thin ice. The distinction between foundation and coherentist conceptions of the true or real has generated a literature all its own, and I do not attempt to do it justice here. The relation between these categories and realism of various kinds is another matter of importance to theological method, and I hope only to allude to it here.

¹⁹I am convinced that "indirectness" remains the principal method in Barth's later work and is a rather bland translation of his "analogy of faith."

about the human and natural world, as well as to its traditional use in language about God.

Schleiermacher's doctrine of creation, with its new interpretation of method in place, might work like this. The decision to construct all religious utterance about the Creator and the creation from the experience of absolute causality might be seen as a piece of indirectness itself. The first form of dogmatic statement—the exploration and expression of religious consciousness—allows all categories of Christian thought to carry the mark of indirectness. Schleiermacher speaks not of God the Creator, but of the human wonder at its own being and of all natural being that points beyond itself to the Source of all being. What Jacques Maritain called the “intuition of Being” lies close to the heart of Schleiermacher's experience, I think, but at a level of indirectness Maritain discards.²⁰ Consider how deeply Schleiermacher cuts against the grain. Not only are statements about God and the spiritual realm reflected images or abstractions from the contents of consciousness, but so too are all descriptions of reality outside the self, such as “the human species” and “the order of nature.” We must not deny them reality; Schleiermacher does not intend to construct that kind of idealism. But we may speak of their reality outside us only because they dwell within. After all, it is this indwelling of the real, the receptivity and comprehension of the world within the self that makes self-consciousness itself possible, ties the individual to the whole, and communicates the “blessing of the Redeemer” to all generations.

This method of indirectness constrains our hunger for speculation and leads us to speak only of what is immediately given: our world and its dependence taken up in piety. Christian theology must conclude from its experience that God cannot be thought of apart from the world; creation expresses the eternal will of God, uttered through the eternal word, and descriptions of creation must coincide with, indeed must collapse into, those of preservation. An eternal creation, after all, poses no problem for Schleiermacher. The relation between God and the world is neither temporal nor spatial; God must not be thought “before” the creation, nor “above” it. In fact, to speak of God “apart from the world” or “in himself,” Schleiermacher argues, is to introduce into the utter simplicity and completeness of the divine Being an element of multiplicity, of time and space.²¹ Once the Creator is drawn into the realm of opposition and change, even if to pro-

²⁰This intuition forms the basis of Maritain's reformulation of the Thomistic demonstrations of the existence of God. See, for example, Jacques Maritain, *On the Uses of Philosophy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1961) essay 3.

²¹Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 152–56; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 198–204.

claim loudly that God is “altogether other” than creation, Christian theology has given itself over to pantheism. Again and again, Schleiermacher returns to this sensitive point. If God is addressed directly and placed in identity or, more troubling, in contradiction to the world, no escape can be found from the charge of pantheism.²²

Like the world itself, God can be viewed under the categories of the object; the divine Being is subsumed under the realm of space and time. Schleiermacher considered much Christian doctrine of his time as proclaiming an immanence of God dressed up in the language of transcendence.²³ It is not enough, and yet altogether too much, to say that God exists beyond the creation, or within it as well as without it, or in sovereign and hidden isolation from it; all these expressions of divine creativity are little more than the generativity of the universe, called by another name. Christian doctrine can avoid pantheism only through a systematic principle, a method of indirectness. God cannot be identical or eminent to “finite causality,” nor can eternity be contrasted to temporality. Rather, God must be distinguished from creation by turning to our experience of grace. God must be implied as that absolute and simple origin upon which we are utterly dependent and over which we exercise no freedom or mastery. Our Christian introspection reveals that God must be unique, beyond the identity and opposition of our experience, eternally distinct from creation by the constant power of the divine. God and the world, far from remaining separate, are brought together in faith as the only sure protection from pantheism.

“There is nothing left in divine knowledge to which there is no correlative in existence.”²⁴ The logic of Schleiermacher’s position is inexorable: the Christian doctrine of creation and preservation teaches that “everything can happen and has happened only as God originally willed and always willed.”²⁵ We must not allow ourselves to imagine, if we are to think theologically, that this world might have been different than it is, that human history might have followed another course, that God might have willed other worlds and other ways. Such speculation, Schleiermacher stresses, arises from human attempts to speak directly of God and to imagine that a place outside piety exists where the God who is not yet Creator can be seen and comprehended. The “naked and hidden God,” even the

²²Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 174; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 229.

²³Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 142–49; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 185–95.

²⁴Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 222; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 293.

²⁵Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 177; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 232.

“speculative” God of Leibniz, finds no room in Schleiermacher’s thought or experience.²⁶

Nevertheless, Schleiermacher’s doctrine is no static, lifeless affair. Christians are not to teach that the creation lies inert in its appointed place and carries within it only the immutable signs of an unchanging will. Schleiermacher recognized that nature also had a history, and that all earthly things evolve and fall away. Marvelously, his doctrine allows for God’s absolute causality, while preserving creaturely movement and change. The freedom of the Christian in faith, the responsibility and unity of the human species can never contradict or oppose the causality of God; this divine causality “lies further back” than the worldly course of cause and effect. Nor can human knowledge ever supersede or oppose the divine Being. Not simply the unknown, but, even more, the known points to the Creator and to the one self-existent Ground from which all things arise.²⁷ Indeed, the “original perfection” of the world and of humanity rests not upon some paradise before history, but upon the organic unity of creation, complete at every moment, in which some are perfect in act and others perfect in potency, waiting their development in the history of nature and the species. The evil in creation, natural and moral, must be understood as bound up in the good; God wills the whole, in which some parts, in our time and space, are not yet complete nor alive to piety. All worldly history unfolds this purpose, namely, to develop all that lies within its power and to raise up all matter into the spirit of absolute dependence upon God.

The advantages Schleiermacher’s system offers us here can scarcely be exaggerated. The tiresome debates over creation and creationism fall silent when we speak not of God before creation, but of the creation—our time, our space—exhibiting in its life a foundation that is not its own. We reduce to nonstarters the propositions that pit free will against providence and knowledge against belief. We find, moreover, a methodological distinction between Creator and creation, consistent and subtle, that breaks our reliance upon such weak supports as “transcendence,” “eminence,” and “aseity.” The controversies over nature and grace, original perfection and fall, moral and natural evil are given new focus and power. No longer a speculation about human origin and consummation, the perfection of creation lies within the dynamism of the cosmos itself. Combining freedom and constraint, nature and spirit, history and providence, Schleiermacher’s doctrine sets the

²⁶Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, 241; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 317.

²⁷The parallels to the neo-Kantian conceptions of “origin,” “ground,” and “generativity” are striking, and, in Karl Barth’s mind at least, not coincidental. For Barth’s reliance upon Cohen and Natorp see Simon Fisher’s *Revelatory Positivism?* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1988) chaps. 4 and 5.

divine will over a part and whole that breathe of a living God and work together for good.

Christian thought, however, cannot rest easy in this return to Schleiermacher. This system of indirectness, or—to phrase it more positively—this method of mediation can be found in the *Christian Faith*, and I hope I have shown that it can be put to work in contemporary theology. But it is the point of mediation, the center of indirectness, that confines and disrupts theology stemming from Schleiermacher. Any method of indirectness requires some point of directness or identity if it is to be more than pure paradox or incoherence. Even the young Barth located an identity point beyond dialectic in the *Ursprung*, the unintuitable and eschatological moment of union between thought and being, God and creation. For Schleiermacher, that point of unity was human experience. The “objects” of faith—God, Christ, and creation—are grasped indirectly and expressed only incompletely in doctrine. They are not, however, without a center of mediation, a point of identity. God and the world are given *immediately* to faith; pious self-consciousness is the moment of directness within the system of dialectics. It is this very fact of piety, laid down as source of doctrine, that threatens Christian thought. It is neither intolerable nor forbidden; but it is dangerous all the same. “I warn!” Barth used to say, pointing to the temptations of the Spirit.²⁸ We can hear him here, too. “I warn!” he might repeat, and put his finger on this place, the pious center of indirect speech about God. Theology should heed this warning.

A theology of indirectness honors the past, but does not forget the warnings. It honors the rhythm, the motion of Schleiermacher’s system: from the inner outward into speech; from the present into the past; from self into text; and from the world, within and without the self, down and beyond into God. Always Schleiermacher points to God, not directly, not objectively, but brokenly, through the mediation of the self, the “species consciousness” of humanity, and the witnesses of the faith. The doctrine of creation is just this sort of mediated theology. The relation of God to the world—the enactment of theological method—is expressed in the *Christian Faith* through the mediation of all parts with the whole. As we take our part in this whole, we find intimations, reflections of the One who supports, grounds, and causes all things, in absolute and eternal power. Schleiermacher’s Christology, by far the longest part of the System of Doctrine, takes this structure of mediation and indirectness, deepens and makes it real within history.²⁹ It is just this experience of the relation of

²⁸Barth, *The Theology of Schleiermacher*, 279.

²⁹Schleiermacher, “Second Aspect of the Antithesis Explication of the Consciousness of Grace,” in *Christian Faith*, 355–476; *Der Christliche Glaube*, 2. 11–90.

dependence that is communicated in Christ through the church. We may agree with Barth, for other reasons, that Jesus Christ “fits terribly” into Schleiermacher’s theology, but it is not for lack of systematic unity.³⁰ The method, doctrine, and piety of the *Christian Faith* connect, mediate, and reflect one another with an unmistakable elegance and power.

A theology of indirectness also remembers the warnings. It moves beyond the rhythm of Schleiermacher’s doctrine to its center. This moment of identity, this subject of mediation, is the Trinitarian God and not the pious consciousness, the self anchored deep and partially free, or the Christocentric Christ of modern theology. This point is directed to the ground and the sum of Christian theological method from Schleiermacher to Barth. Christology, however central to this tradition, is the necessary but not the sufficient foundation of all Christian doctrine and method. The sufficient doctrine—and, I believe, the only sufficiency—is the symbol and living grace of the Trinity. In uttering the words “Jesus Christ,” Barth intended this Triune One who loves in freedom. He meant to point to this relation between the Creator and creation, the One elected and electing, the Word in whom and through whom all things are made. As his *Church Dogmatics* continued, however, Barth returned each time more profoundly to the tradition begun with Schleiermacher’s *Christian Faith* to trace once again the outline of this Royal Man, to tell the somber and majestic story of this Son of Man in his journey to the far country and to relate all things back to the blessing achieved by this Jesus of Nazareth. But Christian theology and a method of indirectness call us to ground this tradition, to encompass, honor, and transcend it in the doctrine of the Trinity. God alone is the center of Christian thought, the one moment of immediacy between creating and creation, and it is the doctrine of the divine Trinity that sets apart Christian claims from all others. To this center of mediation, all broken thoughts and lives return; within this Trinity “the whole” truly resides in “each, and each in the whole.” As Schleiermacher teaches us, the relation of God and creation—the method of Christian theology—begins with God the Creator, who speaks in shadows and figures, not with the naked and unimaginable God beyond creation. From this God, the original Whole and Part, the world is uttered, and we receive this Word. As we echo the Word in our human and incomplete way, our repetition constitutes theology. From the Holy One and Three, the Judge, the Origin, the Voice of the prophets and apostles, the eternal and self-giving Glory—from this God theology receives its life and to this One it hands it over again.

³⁰See Barth’s diagnosis, for example, in Karl Barth, *Protestant Theology in the 19th Century* (trans. B. Cozens and J. Bowden; London: SCM, 1972) 432.